

it, however, the micokernel approach highly reduces computer crashes, and the small number of lines of code in the operating system makes it more bug free.

Trovalds borrowed heavily from GNU, using a lot of existing free software, including the compiler, which is a basic component of the Linux kernel. This includes the glibc library, which is the GNU library for the C language. Linux was instantly picked up by the Open Source community, and developed many flavors or distributions. The early ones included SLS (Softlanding Linux System), Slackware, OpenSUSE and Red Hat. Currently, there are more than 350 Linux distributions, with different releases, offering varied degrees of support, and suitable for many needs.

One of the mainstays of Linux has been the GPL license. The GPL license, is like the EULA (End User Agreement License) of proprietary software and operating systems, only without the restrictive terms and conditions. When you buy a disc with the Windows installation, for example, you don't buy the operating system at all, but a license to use the operating system on a single computer. You are not allowed to install the operating system on multiple machines, share it with friends, or modify it for individual use. Restrictions include something as basic as changing the interface and how it looks. The GPL license on Linux does away with many of these restrictions. That does not mean the the GPL itself is without any problems. GPL is highly controversial within the open source community itself, and amongst software developers in general. Many claim that the GPL has no legal weight whatsoever, and software released under the GPL are essentially ambiguous in license or public domain. The GPL does not protect contributors to a project that is falsely released under the GPL by an unscrupulous programmer. Since anyone is allowed to modify and redistribute software, GPL makes original developers almost anonymous. Due to the many shortcomings of GPL, Linux is licensed under GPL v. 2.0, whereas a later version of the license is available and used as the license for many a Linux based software. However, the GPL is still a robust, well established and open license for software distribution, and one of the reasons why Linux has risen in popularity. It allowed adopters of Linux to make changes, and re-release, spawning a horde of Linux distributions.

There are also commercially supported distributions, which have helped the spread of Linux the most. These include Red Hat, SUSE, and Ubuntu. Many companies have switched to Linux as a